

“... there shone Frederick,
the pole star around
whom Germany... even
the world seemed to turn.”

JOHANN WOLFGANG VON GOETHE, GERMAN
WRITER, ON FREDERICK THE GREAT, c. 1833

1740

FREDERICK THE GREAT BECOMES KING OF PRUSSIA

Frederick the Great (1712-86) transformed Prussia into a significant European power, expanding its territories, notably through the first partition of Poland (1772). An Enlightenment monarch, Frederick published his own writings and was a keen patron of the sciences and arts, supporting musicians including Johann Sebastian Bach and building the Berlin State Opera.



△ Frederick the Great playing the flute at Sanssouci

1740 Baal Shem Tov
develops Hasidism, an
influential Jewish revivalist
movement, in Poland

1740

**1741 Johann Sebastian
Bach** publishes the *Goldberg
Variations*, a key work of
Baroque music



△ Austrian camp on the River Danube

1740

WAR OF THE AUSTRIAN SUCCESSION BEGINS

The death of the Holy Roman Emperor Charles VI in 1740 sparked a series of conflicts (to 1748) over his daughter Maria Theresa's right to succeed to his Austrian lands and her husband to his title. The war drew in Prussia, Bavaria, France, Spain, Sweden, Russia, Britain, and Hanover. Maria Theresa secured her inheritance, ruling with her husband and then her son as emperor until 1780, but Austria was weakened and many issues remained unresolved.

1742 THE CELSIUS TEMPERATURE SCALE

Swedish physicist Anders Celsius (1701-44) proposed a temperature scale with 100 degrees between the freezing and boiling points of water on a mercury thermometer. Celsius set the boiling point at 0 and freezing point at 100, but this was reversed by his colleague Martin Strömer in 1750.



△ Mercury in a glass Celsius thermometer from c. 1790